

SecureDrop: Making Whistleblowing Possible

Kushal Das is bright, Indian and articulate. He is one of the small but growing number of *desi* techies involved with global FOSS projects. But he plays an unusual role today, and speaks a language that focuses on press freedom, whistleblowers, and allowing journalists to work effectively. His current area of focus is SecureDrop, which he describes as “a widely used secure digital platform for sources to anonymously submit materials to journalists.”

From being a hard-core techie, Kushal Das has taken on new roles – looking deep into how technology can help society, in very direct ways. And to do this, he focuses on the seemingly abstract (but very real) issue of press freedom. His weapon: SecureDrop.

SecureDrop allows journalists to hear from all possible sources, and from whistleblowers. Both can communicate securely with each other, using this tool.

Kushal Das was one of the founders of the Linux Users' Group of Durgapur, the third largest city in West Bengal, after Kolkata and Asansol. Some among us might recall this LUG as an active group. Its online tracks and archives can now be found at dgplug.org/archive/.

Das says that the year 2005 marked his first FOSS.in conference, which was organised by the late Atul Chitnis and team, at Bengaluru. He adds, “I worked all my life on free software projects, nine years of that officially at Red Hat, and the last three years as a Fedora Cloud Engineer. I’m a core developer of Python, and have also been part of many different projects. At one time, I had commit permissions in KDE, and now am also part of the core member team of the Tor Project.”

Kushal Das describes himself in a brief online ‘Linux User’s Manual’ thus: “Public interest technologist



Kushal Das

at Freedom of the Press Foundation. Spends life helping various FOSS projects and communities in different roles. Part of the Tor Project Core team, a core developer of CPython, and director at Python Software Foundation. In 2004, I founded dgplug and still help there as a co-ordinator. I spend a lot of time with new contributors in #dgplug channel on freednode.”

More recently, Das has been spending time working on and raising awareness about SecureDrop.

SecureDrop was earlier called DeadDrop. It was co-created by noted

transparency activist Aaron Swartz (1986-2013). Swartz’s life is a story in itself. To put it briefly, the young techie, political organiser and hactivist committed suicide after the police arrested him in a controversial, high-profile case. (For more details, see ‘The Story of Aaron Swartz’ documentary via YouTube; the link is given in the References section.)

Later, this software was called Strongbox. In 2013, it was first deployed by *The New Yorker*, the weekly magazine known for its journalism, commentary, criticism, essays, fiction, satire, cartoons and poetry. The Freedom of the Press Foundation took it up, and SecureDrop is now used by many major organisations worldwide. Among these are *The Washington Post*, *The Guardian*, *ProPublica*, *Gawker*, *HuffPost* and *The Intercept*, apart from *The New Yorker*. A study shows that SecureDrop has actually led to many stories being published.

When I briefly met Kushal Das at Goa, he said, “We defend and protect public interest journalists and media organisations. We build tools and technologies to work together.”

Das says that the two important aspects of the SecureDrop work cater to journalists and whistleblowers. A whistleblower is someone who exposes any information or activity that is illegal, unethical or incorrect,